Pakistan in Brisbane; that was the first time South Africa played in the Cricket World Cup and that was the match made famous by Jonty Rhodes' diving run-out.

Did I sit there in the living room and dream of one day playing on that same stage?

No, in truth, that prospect seemed unimaginable.

In June 1995, while a newly, miraculously united country was becoming steadily more and more excited by the Springboks' progress in the Rugby World Cup hosted in our own country, my mother created our own 'executive box' in our living room, from where we watched all the Bok matches on television. With our faces painted in the colours of the new rainbow flag for the new rainbow nation, every game was a huge event.

More than 40 friends and family came to our house to watch the final against New Zealand. What a day! It was incredible to see how sport could bring so much joy to so many people.

I loved every minute of these big sporting occasions.

Almost without exception, I celebrated wildly whenever South Africa won. When South Africa lost, almost without exception, I cried.

The years passed. My brothers moved on to university and their careers. I found myself spending more and more time at home, alone, challenged to amuse myself. That was no problem.

If I wanted to play cricket, I put a ball in the bottom of a sock, hung it from the ceiling of the garage and played drive after drive, getting the feel of the ball in the middle of the bat, over and over again.

If I felt like playing tennis, there was a net marked out on the inside wall of the garage and I developed a game where I would play against 'the computer'. That meant serving as me, returning the rebounding ball as 'the computer', then playing as me and on and on until the point was won; the key, I soon learned, was to hit every stroke as hard as possible and to the very best of my ability. I never cheated.